

What happened to the livestock watering policy?

The development of a new livestock watering policy has been paused and will not be completed before the March 1, 2022 existing use groundwater (EUGW) transitioning deadline. Livestock watering remains defined as an “industrial” water use purpose and all industrial livestock watering requires a water authorization under the Water Sustainability Act (WSA).

What about livestock producers using groundwater?

If a livestock producer’s use of groundwater began before March 1, 2016, they are considered an “existing user” and are encouraged to apply for an existing use groundwater (EUGW) licence prior to the March 1, 2022 deadline. If groundwater use began on or after March 1, 2016, the livestock producer is considered as a “new user” and they must apply for a water licence before they can lawfully begin diverting and using groundwater.

What about livestock producers using surface water?

All livestock producers using surface water require a water authorization. A person who takes water without an authorization has no legal standing to use the water. If drought or water scarcity occurs, unauthorized users are the first to be ordered to cease diverting water. This requirement to licence surface water for livestock watering purpose was in place under the former Water Act and remains so under the WSA.

Should I wait for new livestock regulations?

No, you should not wait. If you need water for your operation, apply now rather than waiting for potential future changes. Livestock watering rules have been discussed in policy work, but the current requirement is still to get a water authorization for industrial livestock watering.